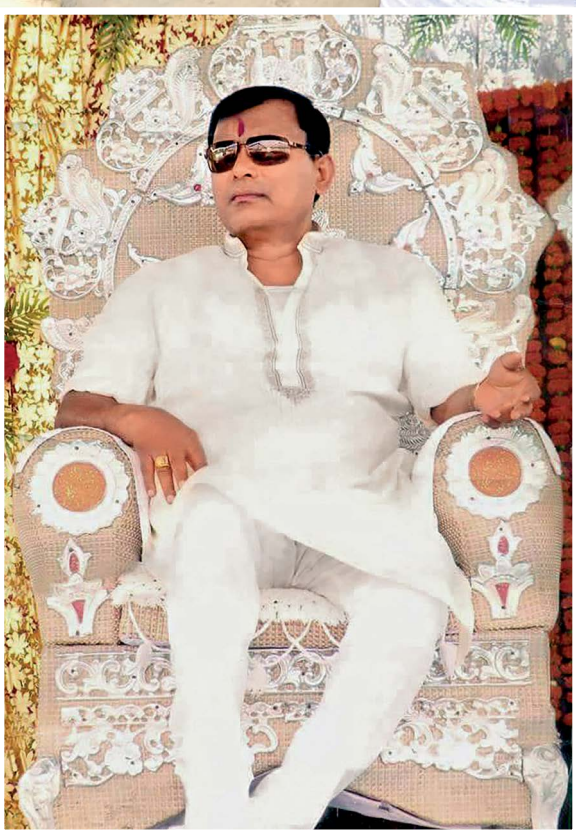


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WHO IS BHOLE BABA?

Born Suraj Pal Singh in a Dalit family of Bahadur Garh village in Etah district, he claims to have been a policeman who worked at the local intelligence unit when a 'divine encounter' led him to quit his job and embark on the path to spirituality. Moving into a mud hut in his native village, and grandly christening himself Narayan Sakar Hari, he began amassing a huge following with his simple discourses on spirituality. Bhole Baba is the name his followers have given to the 58-year-old godman.

Unlike *bhagwa-dhari* (saffron-clad) babas, he is attired in a white suit, often with a tie, or in a simple kurta-pyjama. He is often accompanied by his wife Premvati, who is addressed as Matashree.

Devotees are given some kind of holy water at his gatherings. "Whenever I have faced a problem, it gets resolved if I drink the water given by Bhole Baba," says Rekha Devi, 33. Raju Kumar, 35, a devotee from Mainpuri district, also likes it that the baba does not solicit "chadhava" or donations.